Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Nehemiah

Nehemiah 1:1

- Artaxerxes I ruled Persia from 465 to 424 BC.
- The fortress of Susa served as the Persian king's winter palace.

Nehemiah 1:1–2.20

When Nehemiah heard about Jerusalem's ruins, he prayed for God's help (Nehemiah 1:1–11) and asked the king to send him to Jerusalem (2:1–8). Upon arrival, he urged the people to rebuild the city's wall (Nehemiah 2:11–20).

Nehemiah 1:2

- Hanani might have been one of Nehemiah's actual brothers. In Hebrew, this word can also mean a fellow countryman (for example, Deuteronomy 1:16).
- the remnant of the Jews who had survived the exile: See Ezra 2:64–65; 8:1–14.

Nehemiah 1:3

- The wall of Jerusalem is broken down: This likely refers to a recent event in Jerusalem (see Ezra 4:6–23), not the Babylonian conquest in 586 BC.
- disgrace: Foreigners could mock the destroyed city, claiming it showed that Israel's God was too weak to protect it (compare Joel 2:17; Micah 7:8–10).

Nehemiah 1:4

Nehemiah mourned, fasted, and prayed for about four months (compare Nehemiah 1:1; 2:1), deeply worried about Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 1:5–11

Nehemiah's prayer includes:

- Praise (Nehemiah 1:5)
- Confession (Nehemiah 1:6–7)
- Remembering God's promises (Nehemiah 1:8–9)
- A request (Nehemiah 1:10–11)

Nehemiah understood that Israel's situation was not due to God failing His covenant of unfailing love. Instead, Israel's ongoing sin led to the punishments described in the covenant.

Nehemiah 1:6

I confess the sins that we Israelites have committed: Like Ezra (Ezra 9:5–15) and Daniel (Daniel 9:4–19), Nehemiah identified with his people's sins. He made no excuses and accepted his own responsibility and that of the larger covenant group that had sinned against God.

Nehemiah 1:8–9

- Nehemiah remembers God's curse on sin and his promise to restore (Deuteronomy 4:25–31; 30:1–5).
- The place…for My Name was Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 1:10

Nehemiah refers to God's long-standing covenant with the Israelites. God rescued them during the exodus (Deuteronomy 9:29) and made them his servants.

Nehemiah 1:11

- grant him mercy in the sight of this man: Nehemiah knew God could make the king kind to him.
- As a cup-bearer, Nehemiah tasted the king's wine to ensure it was safe. This role gave him daily access to King Artaxerxes.

Nehemiah 2:1

never been sad in his presence: A servant should not let personal issues affect serving the king.

Nehemiah 2:2

Nehemiah felt scared because he showed his sadness and did not know how the king would react if he explained why he was upset. King Artaxerxes had earlier ordered that Jerusalem should not be rebuilt (Ezra 4:21–22). Nehemiah was not pretending; his deep mourning was visible despite his efforts to hide it.

Nehemiah 2:3

Nehemiah showed his loyalty by saying, May the king live forever! (compare Daniel 2:4), but he still admitted his sadness.

Nehemiah 2:4

What is your request?: The king followed the God of heaven, and Nehemiah needed God's guidance and help for his request.

Nehemiah 2:5

send me to Judah…so that I may rebuild it: Artaxerxes' willingness to consider this proposal is surprising given Jerusalem's history of rebellions against Persia (Ezra 4:17–23). The king might have seen Nehemiah's plan as a way to strengthen his control over a problematic area of his empire.

Nehemiah 2:6

How long will your journey take (see Ezra 5:14): Nehemiah likely asked for a short time at first and later requested more time.

Nehemiah 2:8

- Temple fortress might mean the Tower of Hananel or the Tower of the Hundred.
- the gracious hand of my God was upon me: Nehemiah understood that God guided the king to grant these requests.

Nehemiah 2:9

Nehemiah was a government official, so officers and horsemen escorted him to Jerusalem (compare Ezra 8:22).

Nehemiah 2:10

- Some local non-Jewish officials were unhappy because rebuilding Jerusalem's walls would shift political power to the Jews.
- Sanballat led the opposition to Nehemiah's rebuilding efforts.
- the Horonite: He was likely from Upper or Lower Horon (Beth-horon, Joshua 16:3), about 19 kilometers (12 miles) northwest of Jerusalem. Sanballat's name suggests he might have descended from the Assyrians brought by Sargon II after Samaria's fall (2 Kings 17:24). A document found in Egypt shows he became Samaria's governor in 408 BC.

Nehemiah 2:12–15

Nehemiah needed to see the walls himself to make strong plans for rebuilding and to gather the workers he needed. He secretly checked the walls at night to avoid being seen by his enemies. He only inspected the southern part of the city.

Nehemiah 2:13

- Jackal's Well might have been En-rogel, a water source about 365 meters (400 yards) south of the city, or the Pool of Siloam, which fills with water from Hezekiah's winding tunnel.
- The Dung Gate, called the Potsherd Gate in Jeremiah 19:2, is at the southern end of the western wall (see Nehemiah 3:13) and led to the Hinnom Valley, where city inhabitants threw their garbage.

Nehemiah 2:14

The King's Pool was likely the Pool of Siloam or another pool southeast of the city. Both pools were made from the overflow of the Gihon Spring (see 2 Kings 20:20).

Nehemiah 2:16–17

- Nehemiah kept his inspection and rebuilding plans secret from both the Persian and Jewish leaders to prevent organized opposition. Now, Nehemiah was ready to lead the rebuilding effort.
- the trouble we are in: The broken walls brought disgrace to the city and reflected poorly on God. Jerusalem certainly did not resemble the city of the great King (Psalm 48:2).

Nehemiah 2:18

Clear evidence of God's involvement (Nehemiah 2:8) strongly motivates any project. Nehemiah had God's guidance, the king's permission, the letters needed to get lumber, and a plan to lead the project. As a result, the people eagerly agreed to start working.

Nehemiah 2:19

- Nehemiah's enemies quickly mocked and tried to halt progress. These opponents were dangerous because they could discourage the people and damage Nehemiah's credibility.
- Are you rebelling against the king?: This serious accusation could lead to death (see also Ezra 4:6–23).

Nehemiah 2:20

The title God of heaven showed Persian audiences that Israel's true God was not just a local god. Nehemiah focused on obeying his ruler by building the walls.

Nehemiah 3:1

- Eliashib, the high priest and grandson of Jeshua (Nehemiah 12:10), led the priests in repairing the northern wall around the temple.
- The Sheep Gate was where people brought sheep for sacrifice at the temple.
- The Tower of the Hundred and the Tower of Hananel were two major military towers along the northern wall (Nehemiah 12:39; Jeremiah 31:38; Zechariah 14:10).

Nehemiah 3:1–5

Eight work groups rebuilt the walls and gates in the city's northern section.

Nehemiah 3:1–32

This summary describes the people who rebuilt Jerusalem's walls. It moves in a circle around the city,

starting at the northeast corner, then going west, south, east, and north.

Nehemiah 3:3

At the Fish Gate, people sold fish from the Sea of Galilee and the Mediterranean Sea.

Nehemiah 3:4

- Meremoth: See Ezra 8:33.
- Meshullam married his daughter to Tobiah's son (Nehemiah 6:18; see also 10:20).

Nehemiah 3:5

Geshem, who controlled the area south of Tekoa, might have influenced Tekoa's leaders (Nehemiah 2:19).

Nehemiah 3:6

The Jeshanah Gate: The oldest part of Jerusalem was on an eastern hill that extended north to the Temple Mount.

Nehemiah 3:6–8

These verses describe the work on the walls and gates on the western side of Jerusalem. People from outside the city and those with wealth or delicate jobs also helped.

Nehemiah 3:7

Gibeon and Mizpah are about ten kilometers (six miles) north of Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 3:8

The Broad Wall stood in the newer, western part of the city.

Nehemiah 3:9–13

Nehemiah wisely assigned people to work near their homes. This motivated them to do good work and saved them travel time.

Nehemiah 3:11

The Tower of the Ovens on the city's western wall might have been used for baking bread or polishing pottery (Jeremiah 19:1–2).

Nehemiah 3:13

Zanoah was a village located about 21 kilometers (13 miles) southwest of Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 3:14

The Beth-haccherem district could have been about 3.2 kilometers (two miles) south of Jerusalem, at what is now Ramat Rachel, or eight kilometers (five miles) west, at what is now Ain Karem.

Nehemiah 3:14–15

These verses focus on rebuilding the southern tip of the city where the Hinnom Valley and Kidron Valley meet.

Nehemiah 3:15

- The Mizpah district was about ten kilometers (six miles) north of Jerusalem.
- The king's garden was a lush area east of the pool of Siloam. It was near the meeting point of the Kidron and Hinnom Valleys, possibly at the King's Pool (Nehemiah 2:14).

Nehemiah 3:16

- The district of Beth-zur was just north of Hebron.
- The tombs of David's family might refer to where King David was buried (1 Kings 2:10; 11:43; 2 Chronicles 21:20; Acts 2:29). The House of the Mighty might have been a tomb for David's mighty men (2 Samuel 23:8–39).

Nehemiah 3:16–32

These verses describe how they built the new eastern wall.

Nehemiah 3:24

The angle and the corner refer to an unknown bend in the wall.

Nehemiah 3:25–26

The tower rising from the king's upper house and the court of the guard likely refers to a royal complex on Ophel Hill, just south of the temple area.

Nehemiah 3:28–32

- This final group of workers completed the repairs at the Sheep Gate, where the work had begun (Nehemiah 3:1).
- Horse Gate: See 2 Chronicles 23:15; Jeremiah 31:40.
- East Gate: See 1 Chronicles 26:14, 17; 2 Chronicles 31:14; Ezekiel 10:19; 40:21–22.

Nehemiah 4:2

- The Persians placed Samarian army officers in Jerusalem to maintain peace.

- feeble Jews: Sanballat's mockery had some truth. The Jews were not wealthy, powerful, or numerous. However, Sanballat did not understand the strength of the God the Jews served.
- Can they restore...Will they offer sacrifices?: Sanballat might have mocked the sudden increase in sacrifices at the temple as the Israelites dedicated their work to the Lord.
- burnt stones...mounds of rubble: When fire destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, it heated the stones, causing some to crack and crumble. The people used these stones to rebuild the walls.

Nehemiah 4:4

Nehemiah prayed intensely for God to stop those who opposed God's will. Nehemiah often called out to God when he needed help (Nehemiah 2:4; 5:19; 6:14; 13:14, 22, 29, 31).

Nehemiah 4:5

Do not...let their sin be blotted out from Your sight: See also "Prayers for Vengeance" Theme Note.

Nehemiah 4:6

half its height: The wall might be 3.0 to 3.7 meters (ten to 12 feet) tall. Some scholars think the original wall was six to 7.3 meters (20 to 24 feet) high.

Nehemiah 4:7

Enemies of Israel from the north (Sanballat), south (Arabs), east (Ammonites), and west (Ashdodites) were angry about Jerusalem's fast and successful rebuilding. This progress threatened their political power in the area.

Nehemiah 4:9

we prayed...and posted a guard: This wise approach to the threat involved both trusting in God and taking necessary actions.

Nehemiah 4:11

The constant psychological attacks from Israel's enemies were lowering morale.

Nehemiah 4:12

Wherever you turn, they will attack us: Jews from nearby areas might have urged the people working in Jerusalem to return to their villages to avoid being killed in an attack.

Nehemiah 4:13

Nehemiah responded by placing armed guards at the weakest parts of the wall. He ensured that opponents outside could see the forces ready to defend the city.

Nehemiah 4:14

The greatest reason for hope was Israel's powerful and glorious God, who had saved them from strong nations before (compare 2 Chronicles 32:7–8; Exodus 14:13–14; Deuteronomy 8:1–3; 20:3; Joshua 10:25). Another reason was to protect their families and properties.

Nehemiah 4:15

Nehemiah credited God (see also Nehemiah 2:20; 6:16). God had thwarted them through the people's prayers, the 24-hour patrol, the visible show of force, and confidence in God's protection.

Nehemiah 4:18–19

Nehemiah used the trumpeter to sound the alarm and direct workers to any part of the wall under attack.

Nehemiah 4:20

Our God will fight for us!: Nehemiah used Israel's ancient holy war tradition (Exodus 14:14; Deuteronomy 1:30; 20:4; Joshua 10:14; 23:10) to assure the people that they would win if they trusted in the Lord.

Nehemiah 4:23

Nehemiah and the other leaders were not elitists who rested while others worked hard.

Nehemiah 5:1–13

Severe financial problems almost stopped the wall's completion (Nehemiah 5:1–5), but Nehemiah found a solution (5:6–13).

Nehemiah 5:2

Some farmers stopped growing crops to help build the wall. This left their large families needing food. Someone had to feed their families, or the farmers would stop working on the wall and return to their fields.

Nehemiah 5:3

Some small landowners had mortgaged everything to survive. The famine worsened the problem because grain was scarce and food prices naturally rose.

Nehemiah 5:4

pay the king's tax: Despite the famine, the Persians did not cancel the heavy royal taxes due at harvest time.

Nehemiah 5:5

we are subjecting our sons and daughters to slavery: See Exodus 21:1–11. These families were desperate.

Nehemiah 5:6–7

Nehemiah was very angry, but he controlled himself. He thought it over and then spoke to resolve the conflict instead of worsening it (see James 1:19–20).

Nehemiah 5:9

- walk in the fear of our God: See Leviticus 25:35–43.
- avoid the reproach: See also Nehemiah 1:3; 2:19; 4:1–3.

Nehemiah 5:10

I…have been lending: Nehemiah and his associates made loans without burdening people. Nehemiah's example was to give financial help without causing more debt by charging interest (see Deuteronomy 15:7–11).

Nehemiah 5:11

Nehemiah demanded that the wealthy lenders return the fields and repay the interest (literally the hundredth part), which they should not have collected (see also Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:35–37). The term hundredth part suggests the interest was one percent per month. This was lower than the 20 percent annual rate found in some documents of that time, or the 60 percent annual rate charged at Elephantine in Egypt. However, even a low interest rate violated God's covenant.

Nehemiah 5:12

required of the nobles and officials an oath: Both God and the community would hold them accountable.

Nehemiah 5:14

- This is the first time Nehemiah is mentioned as governor. The king did not mention this role when he first sent Nehemiah to Jerusalem.
- Persia's government officials usually received an official food allowance from the local population. However, Nehemiah and his associates bought food with their regular pay instead.

Nehemiah 5:14–19

This section explains Nehemiah's steady approach to servant leadership and his personal generosity.

Nehemiah 5:15

The former governors were likely Nehemiah's immediate predecessors, not Sheshbazzar (Ezra 1:8, around 90 years earlier) or Zerubbabel (Haggai 1:1, around 80 years earlier).

Nehemiah 5:19

Nehemiah prayed for God to remember and bless him, showing his reliance on God.

Nehemiah 6:1–19

After solving the financial crisis (see Nehemiah 5), the story shifts back to how those against rebuilding tried to scare or stop Nehemiah.

Nehemiah 6:2

The plain of Ono, located near Lod (Ezra 2:33), was likely a neutral site west of Jerusalem. Nehemiah would have been unprotected there.

Nehemiah 6:6–7

- plotting to revolt…become their king: Those who opposed rebuilding the temple used similar tactics (see Ezra 4).
- At times in Israel's history, prophets helped establish a new king (compare 1 Samuel 9:16; 2 Kings 9).

Nehemiah 6:11

A good leader does not run from danger but stands as an example for their people.

Nehemiah 6:15–16

in fifty-two days: Everyone understood that God's help made this success possible (see also Nehemiah 1:11; 2:8, 18, 20; 4:15, 20).

Nehemiah 7:1

- the wall had been rebuilt: The dedication of the wall is described in Nehemiah 12:27–34.
- The Levites typically helped care for the temple area and guarded its gates.

Nehemiah 7:2

a faithful man who feared God: He showed two leadership traits that Nehemiah and God valued (see also Nehemiah 5:9, 15; Daniel 6:4; Luke 16:10–12; 1 Peter 5:12).

Nehemiah 7:3

The gatekeepers were meant to close the gates in the afternoon when people rested and were not ready

to defend the city. In other texts, similar language describes the hottest part of the day when people go inside (Genesis 18:1; 2 Samuel 4:5).

Nehemiah 7:4–5

Most people lived in the countryside near their fields, so Jerusalem's population was small. A registration would likely encourage more people to settle in and near Jerusalem (Nehemiah 7:73).

Nehemiah 7:6

the exiles…returned to Jerusalem and Judah, each to his own town: These lists were incomplete (the individual numbers do not match the total in Nehemiah 7:66), but they were the best records available to verify Jewish identity.

Nehemiah 7:7

accompanied by: Sheshbazzar (see Ezra 1:8) is not mentioned here and in Ezra 2:2. This suggests both lists were made after the people settled in their towns and after Sheshbazzar died.

Nehemiah 7:8–38

the descendants of: This list is similar to the one in Ezra 2:3–35, but there are some differences in names and family sizes. People were listed by family (Nehemiah 7:8–25) and by the town where they settled (7:26–38). Most of these towns were north of Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 7:39–60

Nehemiah wanted to ensure that only true priests and Levites served in God's temple.

Nehemiah 7:60

The descendants of Solomon's servants likely helped the Levites by carrying wood or sweeping the floor (see Ezra 2:55–58). They might have been Gibeonites (see Joshua 9:23–27; 1 Chronicles 9:35–44) or war captives (see Numbers 31:30–47).

Nehemiah 7:61–62

they could not prove that their families were descended from Israel: They had no family records.

Nehemiah 7:65

Urim and Thummim: See study notes on Exodus 28:30 and Leviticus 8:8.

Nehemiah 7:66

The total number 42,360 matches Ezra 2:64, but the family numbers add up to only 31,089. The family numbers might not include young children, or the list might be incomplete.

Nehemiah 7:70–72

Some family leaders gave gifts, following their ancestors' traditions when building sacred structures (Exodus 25:2–7; 35:4–9; 2 Kings 12:1–21). This money added to gifts from Israelites who remained in Babylon (Ezra 1:6) and from the Persian kings (Ezra 6:8).

Nehemiah 7:73

the Israelites…in their own towns: Each family settled in their ancestral towns throughout Israel, where their ancestors lived before the Exile.

Nehemiah 7:73–10.39

This section, possibly from Ezra's personal memoirs, explains how Ezra's teaching of God's law renewed the people's commitment to serve God and follow his instructions. Spiritual revival occurred alongside the civic work of Ezra and Nehemiah.

Nehemiah 8:1

The Water Gate was in the middle of Jerusalem's eastern wall, south of the temple and east of the palace ruins (Nehemiah 3:26; 12:37). There was a lot of open space, ensuring everyone could gather there.

Nehemiah 8:2

On the first day of the seventh month: The people gathered to celebrate the Feast of Trumpets (Leviticus 23:24–25), marking the start of a new year in the calendar from after the exile in Babylon.

Nehemiah 8:3

- The time from early morning until noon allowed about six hours for reading and interpreting (Nehemiah 8:7–8).
- understand (see also Nehemiah 8:2, 8, 12): This was more than a ritual reading of the law. It included explanations, insights, and applications.

Nehemiah 8:4

These thirteen people were likely community leaders. Some may have helped Ezra roll the scroll while he read.

Nehemiah 8:5

The people stood up to show respect for God's word (Job 29:8). They likely stood the entire time Ezra read.

Nehemiah 8:6

- Ezra blessed the LORD: See also Nehemiah 1:5; 9:32; Deuteronomy 10:17; Jeremiah 32:18; Daniel 9:4.
- Amen! This is a statement of agreement (see Nehemiah 5:13). Lifting hands (Psalm 28:2) and bowing in humble worship showed reverence for God and submission to his word.

Nehemiah 8:7–9

The Levites were responsible for teaching people God's word (Deuteronomy 33:10; Malachi 2:5–6). They likely explained the Hebrew Scriptures to smaller groups in Aramaic. Most people spoke Aramaic, the language of Babylon, instead of Hebrew as their first language. Jewish leaders later translated large parts of the Hebrew Bible into Aramaic, so people could hear and study the Bible in a language they understood.

Nehemiah 8:9–10

- Ezra the priest and scribe: See study note on Ezra 7:6.
- This day is holy to the LORD your God. Do not mourn or weep: God moved the people's hearts, leading them to regret not following his laws. While weeping is a suitable reaction to sin (see Ezekiel 9:4; Luke 6:21), Ezra and Nehemiah urged the people to celebrate what God had done. This New Year's festival was meant to be joyful (Numbers 29:1–6), and weeping would have ruined the day's spirit.

Nehemiah 8:10

- People ate rich foods like meat only on special occasions.
- Sweet drinks meant unfermented juice, unlike the vinegar common laborers drank (see Ruth 2:14).
- It is good to share with those in need (see Deuteronomy 15:11; Job 29:16; Proverbs 31:20; Matthew 6:2–3; Acts 4:34–35).

Nehemiah 8:15

to make booths: The Feast of Tabernacles commemorated when the people of Israel lived in tents during their journey through the wilderness (Leviticus 23:33–43; see also Numbers 29:12–39; Deuteronomy 16:13–15).

Nehemiah 8:16

The Ephraim Gate was likely on the north side of Jerusalem, facing the land of the tribe of Ephraim (see Nehemiah 12:39).

Nehemiah 8:17

From the days of Joshua: Israel had celebrated this festival many times (1 Kings 8:2; 2 Kings 23:22; 2 Chronicles 7:8–10; 30:26; 35:18; Ezra 3:4), but this was a special celebration.

Nehemiah 8:18

Ezra read from the Book of the Law of God: The law was read every seven years at the Feast of Booths (Deuteronomy 31:10–12). This reminded the people of the covenant rules and God's past acts of kindness.

Nehemiah 9:2

Those of Israelite descent separated themselves from all the foreigners, and they stood and confessed their sins: This might refer to the issue of intermarriage with foreigners, as described in Ezra 9–10.

Nehemiah 9:3

They admitted their sins after listening to God's word (compare Nehemiah 8:1–9, 13–14, 18).

Nehemiah 9:5–6

The Levites' prayer praised God for his great reputation and his unique divinity. They acknowledged his creation of the universe and his care for life on earth. Angels worship him. Focusing on God helped Israel understand their current situation better.

Nehemiah 9:5–37

This lengthy prayer admits the nation's sins and praises God for his compassion throughout history (compare Psalms 105–106; 135–136). It encouraged listeners to admit their own unfaithfulness and ask God for compassion and forgiveness.

Nehemiah 9:7–8

God's actions with Abram—calling him (Genesis 12:1–3; 15:7), giving him a new name and identity (Genesis 17:5), making a covenant with him (Genesis 15:6–21; 17:4–5), and fulfilling his promises of land and descendants (Genesis 15:18–21)—showed God's faithfulness and inspired confidence in God's future actions.

Nehemiah 9:9

God noticed his people's suffering under foreign rule (Exodus 2:23–25; 3:7; 14:10–14), similar to their current situation (Nehemiah 9:32–37).

Nehemiah 9:10–11

You made a name for Yourself: In the Exodus, God showed his power with plagues, parting the sea, and defeating the proud Egyptian army (Exodus 15:5, 9–10, 19).

Nehemiah 9:12–21

This prayer reminded the people of God's miraculous guidance of Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 13:21–22), his personal appearance at Mount Sinai to reveal his covenant laws through Moses (see Exodus 19–20), and his faithfulness in providing bread and water (see Exodus 16:4; 17:1–6). Despite all of that, Israel's ancestors were proud and stubborn and refused to obey (see Exodus 32; Numbers 14:4). Yet in his grace, God remained faithful and compassionate (see Exodus 34:6) and provided his spirit to guide and teach them (compare Exodus 33:2; Numbers 11:17).

Nehemiah 9:24

You subdued…the Canaanites: See Joshua 6–12.

Nehemiah 9:25

- Compare Deuteronomy 6:10–11; 8:6–10.
- they ate and were filled; they grew fat: Prosperity included spiritual danger (see Deuteronomy 8:11–20).

Nehemiah 9:26–27

The prayer describes the events in the book of Judges (see Judges 2:11–23).

Nehemiah 9:28–31

The people did not learn from the mistakes made during the time of the judges (Nehemiah 9:26–27). The same pattern of disobedience appeared during the monarchy (compare 2 Kings 17). Despite the nation's ongoing disobedience (Nehemiah 9:29), God remained steadfast in his love, patience, compassion, and guidance through the spirit and the prophets.

Nehemiah 9:32–37

The prayer now addresses the current situation, asking the great God—who has unfailing love—for ongoing love and mercy for his people in their difficult times (Nehemiah 9:32). The leaders acknowledged God's justice in punishing them for their sins (Nehemiah 9:33–35), and they expressed sorrow over their enslavement by the Persians (9:36–37).

Nehemiah 9:38

we make a binding agreement, putting it in writing: These actions shows a serious commitment to the agreement. The sealed document was legally binding.

Nehemiah 9:38–10.39

The people, embracing the prayer, renewed their dedication to God and his word. They signed their names to show their commitment (Nehemiah 9:38–10:27) and took an oath to follow the covenant (10:28–39).

Nehemiah 10:1–27

The list of eighty-four names included:

- The governor, Nehemiah (Nehemiah 10:1)
- A group of priests (Nehemiah 10:2–8; compare 12:1–7)
- Levites (Nehemiah 10:9–13; compare 9:4–5; 12:8–9)
- Leaders (Nehemiah 10:14–27; compare 3:4–31)

Nehemiah 10:28

who had separated themselves from the people of the land: See Nehemiah 9:2; compare with Ezra 9–10.

Nehemiah 10:29

sworn oath to follow the Law of God: Compare Leviticus 26:14–35 and Deuteronomy 28:15–62.

Nehemiah 10:30

Compare Ezra 9–10.

Nehemiah 10:30–39

The community had broadly committed to following the law of Moses. However, they focused on specific issues. These issues involved keeping the community pure and ensuring proper worship at the temple.

Nehemiah 10:31

- Stopping trade on the Sabbath was important for keeping the covenant (compare Nehemiah 13:15–22; see Exodus 16:29; 20:8–11; 31:15; Numbers 15:32–36; Amos 8:5).
- Every seventh year: See Exodus 23:10–11; Leviticus 25:2–7; Deuteronomy 15:1–3.

Nehemiah 10:33

- the showbread: See Leviticus 24:5–9; Numbers 28:1–8.
- for all the duties: The annual tax money allowed priests to buy animals for daily sacrifices and maintain the temple complex (compare 2 Kings 12:11–12; see also Exodus 30:11–16).

Nehemiah 10:34

The fire on the altar burned constantly (Leviticus 6:12), so it required a lot of wood. The Gibeonites supplied it earlier (Joshua 9:27), but now everyone shared the responsibility.

Nehemiah 10:35–37

Community offerings provided food for the priests and Levites, who had no farmland and could not support themselves. These provisions included:

- The first part of every harvest (see Exodus 23:19; 34:26; Numbers 18:12–13; Deuteronomy 26:1–11)
- Redemption money of five shekels for the oldest sons and the firstborn of all herds and flocks (see Exodus 13:13; 34:20; Numbers 18:15–17)
- A tenth of everything (see Numbers 18:21–24; Deuteronomy 14:22–29)

Nehemiah 10:37–39

The Levites gathered tithes in all the rural towns and sent one-tenth of that collection to the temple in Jerusalem (see Numbers 18:25–32).

Nehemiah 11:1–2

Sacred lots were likely the Urim and Thummim (Nehemiah 10:34; Joshua 7:14, 16–18; 14:2).

Nehemiah 11:1–36

The story goes back to the topic of bringing people back to live in the safe city of Jerusalem (see Nehemiah 7:1–5). The list of names is similar to the one in 1 Chronicles 9:2–17.

Nehemiah 11:4

Perez was a son of Judah (Genesis 38:29).

Nehemiah 11:16

Outside the temple, the work likely involved collecting tithes from people and managing them in storehouses (Nehemiah 10:37–39; see also 1 Chronicles 26:29).

Nehemiah 11:17

the son of Asaph: David selected Asaph and his sons to create music for temple worship (1 Chronicles 25:1–8). Asaph's descendants resumed this role when the new temple was built.

Nehemiah 11:21

The hill of Ophel was high ground just south of the temple (Nehemiah 3:26). It was a perfect place for housing temple workers.

Nehemiah 11:24

The royal adviser told the king about events in Jerusalem and informed Jewish officials about the king's management of Persian policies.

Nehemiah 11:30

from Beersheba all the way to the Valley of Hinnom: Earlier descriptions of where people settled focused on areas north of Jerusalem (Nehemiah 3; 11:31–36). This list (Nehemiah 11:25–30) shows the expansion of places where Jewish people lived as they returned to many of their towns from before the exile, both north and south of Jerusalem.

Nehemiah 12:1–9

priests and Levites who went up with Zerubbabel… with Jeshua: See Ezra 1:1–5. Only those who could prove their priestly lineage could serve at the temple. Therefore, maintaining an accurate genealogical record of these families was important.

Nehemiah 12:1–26

These lists of priests and Levites include those who originally returned from exile with Zerubbabel (Nehemiah 12:1–9), a chronological list of high priests (12:10–11), and the priests and Levites who served during Joiakim's time, the high priest during Nehemiah and Ezra's era (12:12–26).

Nehemiah 12:7

- leaders of the priests: Compare Ezra 2:36–39.
- Jeshua was the high priest in Jerusalem when the people returned from captivity shortly after 538 BC (Ezra 2:2; 3:2, 8; 4:3). He continued serving in 520 BC when Haggai and Zechariah encouraged the people to complete the temple (Ezra 5:1; Haggai 1:1; Zechariah 3:1).

Nehemiah 12:8–9

their associates, stood across: To perform antiphonal singing (a call-and-response style) as described in Nehemiah 12:24 and Ezra 3:1–11.

Nehemiah 12:10–11

- Joiakim likely served during the early years of Ezra's service.

- Eliashib and Joiada served during Nehemiah's time (Nehemiah 3:1; 13:4, 28).
- Jonathan: An Aramaic papyrus document from a Jewish colony in Elephantine, Egypt (around 410 BC). Josephus (Antiquities 11.5.4, AD 93) also mentions Jonathan serving after Nehemiah's time.

Nehemiah 12:12–21

This list was likely compiled when Joiakim was the high priest (Nehemiah 12:12) to confirm the legitimacy of the priests and Levites in office. Except for the omission of Hattush (see Nehemiah 12:2), this list includes the same names as Nehemiah 12:1–7.

Nehemiah 12:27–29

- Since few Levites had returned to live in Jerusalem (see Ezra 2:40–42; 8:15–19), leaders recruited all Levites throughout the land to form two impressive choirs and orchestras.
- Netophathites came from near Bethlehem (1 Chronicles 2:54).
- Beth-gilgal was near Jericho.
- Geba and Azmaveth were in the territory of Benjamin.

Nehemiah 12:27–43

The dedication of the new wall likely occurred soon after it was finished (Nehemiah 6:15–19). This account likely came from Nehemiah's personal writings.

Nehemiah 12:30

The dedication ceremony required the priests and Levites to be purified and ready to enter the temple area (see Exodus 19:10; Numbers 8:5–7).

Nehemiah 12:31–37

The impressive march moved south along the top of the wall to the Dung Gate at the city's southern end (Nehemiah 3:13–14). Then the procession went north on the wall along the east side of the city, past the ruins of the house of David, and up to the Water Gate (Nehemiah 3:26; 8:1) near the temple.

Nehemiah 12:35

Long, slender, metal trumpets were played for joyful celebrations (1 Chronicles 13:8; 15:23; 16:6, 42; Ezra 3:10) by Asaph's descendants.

Nehemiah 12:38–39

- The second choir went north along the western wall, passing:
- The Broad Wall (Nehemiah 3:8)
- The Old City Gate (Nehemiah 3:6)
- The Fish Gate (Nehemiah 3:3)

They continued along the northern side of the wall until they reached the Sheep Gate (Nehemiah 3:1) at the northeast corner of the temple.

- The Guard Gate might be the Inspection Gate (Nehemiah 3:31).

Nehemiah 12:43

This community celebration included everyone. God was the true source of their great joy because his power helped them rebuild the walls. Psalm 147 might have been written for this occasion.

Nehemiah 12:44–47

On the day of the wall's dedication (Nehemiah 12:44; 13:1), men were appointed to manage the tithes and gifts for the priests and Levites' needs. Their duties included collecting people's gifts for the priests and Levites (Nehemiah 10:32–39; see also Exodus 30:11–16; 38:25–26), performing services for God (probably sacrifices; see Leviticus 1–5), and overseeing the purification of unclean people. They also purified pans, knives, and clothing used in temple worship as described in Leviticus 11–15 (see also 1 Chronicles 23:28).

Nehemiah 12:46

David gave instructions for organizing the music at the temple (1 Chronicles 23–26). He put Asaph, along with Heman and Jeduthun, in charge of the music (1 Chronicles 25:2–5).

Nehemiah 12:47

From the time the first people returned to Jerusalem with Zerubbabel in 538 BC (Ezra 3:1) until Nehemiah's time around 445 BC, Israelites provided food for temple workers. Most Levites lived in cities across the country. They collected a tithe and brought a tenth of it to the temple in Jerusalem to support its ministry (see Nehemiah 10:38–39).

Nehemiah 13:1–3

On the same day the temple workers were appointed (Nehemiah 12:44), the text from Deuteronomy 23:3–6 was read. It stated that no Ammonite or Moabite should ever enter the assembly of God. Nehemiah later discovered (Nehemiah 13:4–14) that people were no longer following these teachings.

Nehemiah 13:4–5

Eliashib's family married into the families of Sanballat (Nehemiah 13:28) and Tobiah. These men were enemies of the Jewish community (Nehemiah 2:10, 19; 4:1). Tobiah's use of the storeroom reduced space for storing tithes and gifts for temple workers (compare Nehemiah 10:39; 13:10–12; 2 Chronicles 31:11) and limited space for supplies needed for regular worship at the temple (Leviticus 2).

Nehemiah 13:4–14

Eliashib the priest (see Nehemiah 12:10, 22; 13:28) had stopped excluding the Ammonites and Moabites (13:1). The people also stopped giving their tithes to the Levites (Nehemiah 13:10–12). Nehemiah corrected these issues.

Nehemiah 13:6

Nehemiah went back to Persia after serving in Jerusalem for twelve years, from 445 to 433 BC. The text does not specify how long he stayed in Persia, but it was likely no more than a year or two. When he returned to Jerusalem, he discovered Tobiah living in the temple storeroom (Nehemiah 13:1–5).

Nehemiah 13:8–9

- I was greatly displeased…I ordered: When people rejected God's instructions, Nehemiah spoke up.
- Everything related to the temple had to be purified and dedicated to God. This included:
- The clothes that the priests and Levites wore (Exodus 29)
- The priests themselves (Leviticus 8–9)
- The temple building and altars (Leviticus 16:15–33)
- All the holy items (1 Chronicles 23:28)

They were all purified (compare 2 Chronicles 29:5, 15–19).

Nehemiah 13:10–12

Because Tobiah used the storeroom, there was no space to store tithes for feeding the Levites and temple singers (Numbers 18:21–24; see Nehemiah 12:44, 47). They had to farm outside Jerusalem (Nehemiah 12:28–29) to support themselves and could not serve in the temple.

Nehemiah 13:13

they were considered trustworthy: Compare Acts 6:1–6.

Nehemiah 13:14

Nehemiah asked God to remember his good deeds and not abandon him when he needed help. He likely faced opposition from those he corrected. See similar mentions in Nehemiah 13:22, 29, 31.

Nehemiah 13:15–16

People were to stop working on the Sabbath to keep it holy (Exodus 20:8–11; 31:14–17; 35:2–3; Jeremiah 17:19–27).

Nehemiah 13:15–31

Nehemiah made two more changes to bring back correct Sabbath observance (Nehemiah 13:15–22) and correct marriage practices (13:23–31). These two sections follow a similar pattern: Nehemiah found a problem, fixed it, and then asked God for a blessing.

Nehemiah 13:19

The Sabbath starts at sunset on Friday evening and ends at sunset on Saturday evening.

Nehemiah 13:22

show me mercy: Nehemiah's prayer suggests he felt the pressure of this unpopular decision. He knew God's unfailing love, not his popularity, would sustain him.

Nehemiah 13:23–24

The earlier marriage reforms (Nehemiah 9:2; 10:28; Ezra 9:1–10:44) did not last. The children could not speak Hebrew, the language of Judah. This was disastrous because they could not read or understand the Scriptures.

Nehemiah 13:25

- Nehemiah cursed them because the parents avoided Hebrew and did not teach their children the language of the Hebrew Bible. A curse asked God to remove his blessing from people.
- I beat some of these men and pulled out their hair: Some men did not accept Nehemiah's rebuke at first, so he made them swear in the name of God not to marry pagans.

Nehemiah 13:26–27

King Solomon led the nation into sin through his foreign wives (1 Kings 11). If intermarriage with nonbelievers continued, the community would face the same downfall. Nehemiah would not allow that.

Nehemiah 13:28

Even the family of the high priest, who were meant to be Israel's spiritual leaders, participated in the sin of intermarriage with unbelieving foreigners (compare Leviticus 21:14). Nehemiah banished the offender, stripping him of status and removing his rights in the Jewish community.

Nehemiah 13:29

Remember them, O my God: Many likely resented Nehemiah's strong stance against intermarriage in the high priest's family. He prayed for God's judgment on these spiritual leaders who defiled the priesthood.

Nehemiah 13:30–31

These final verses summarize Nehemiah's reform. Nehemiah ensured the people kept their promises. He held them accountable and did not accept half-hearted efforts.